

Not All Roads Lead to the Top

Within the global top 200, universities do not succeed in the same way. Four distinct models emerge, each with its own strengths, ranking pattern, and trajectory over time

Top 200 universities do not show a single profile. Using data reported by Times Higher Education from the top universities in 2024, specifically teaching, research, citations, and international outlook scores, a k-means clustering algorithm was applied and 4 well defined groups emerged:

All-round elite: Consistently high across all dimensions, with no visible weaknesses.

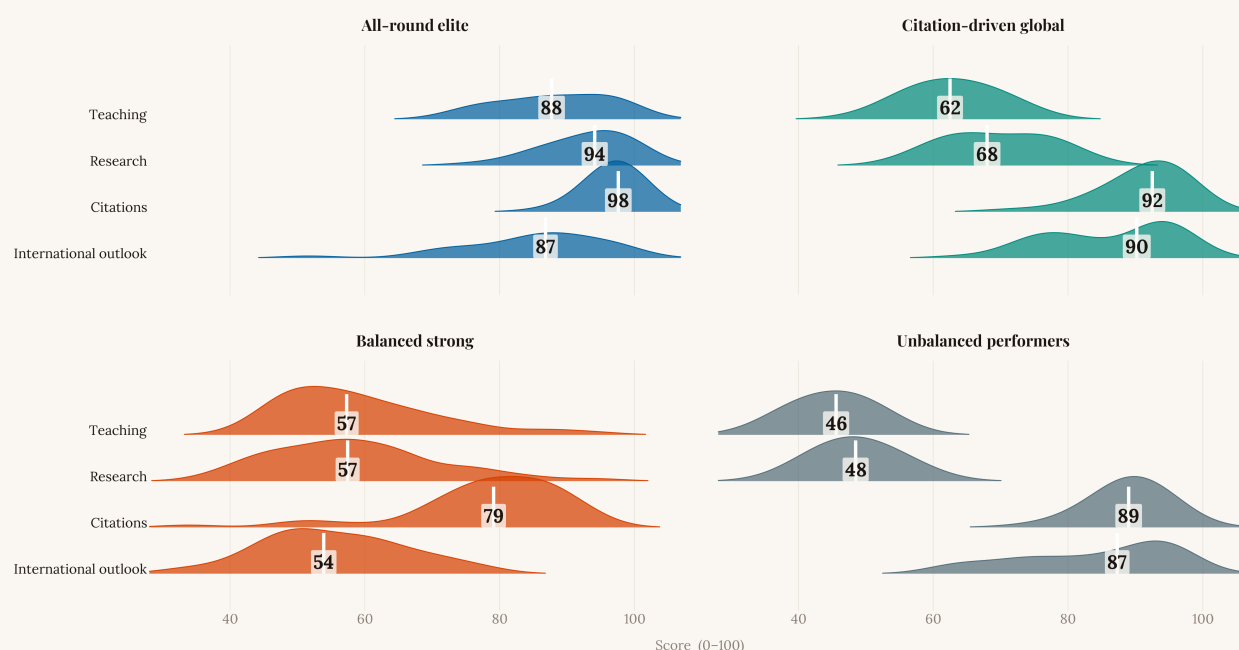
Citation-driven global: Elite citation impact and global reach, but teaching and research reputation lag behind.

Unbalanced performers: Rely on citation impact, leaving teaching and research environment far behind.

Balanced strong: Solid across the board, but no standout strengths.

Not all top universities excel at the same things.

Score distributions across four dimensions. The white line marks the median (50th percentile).

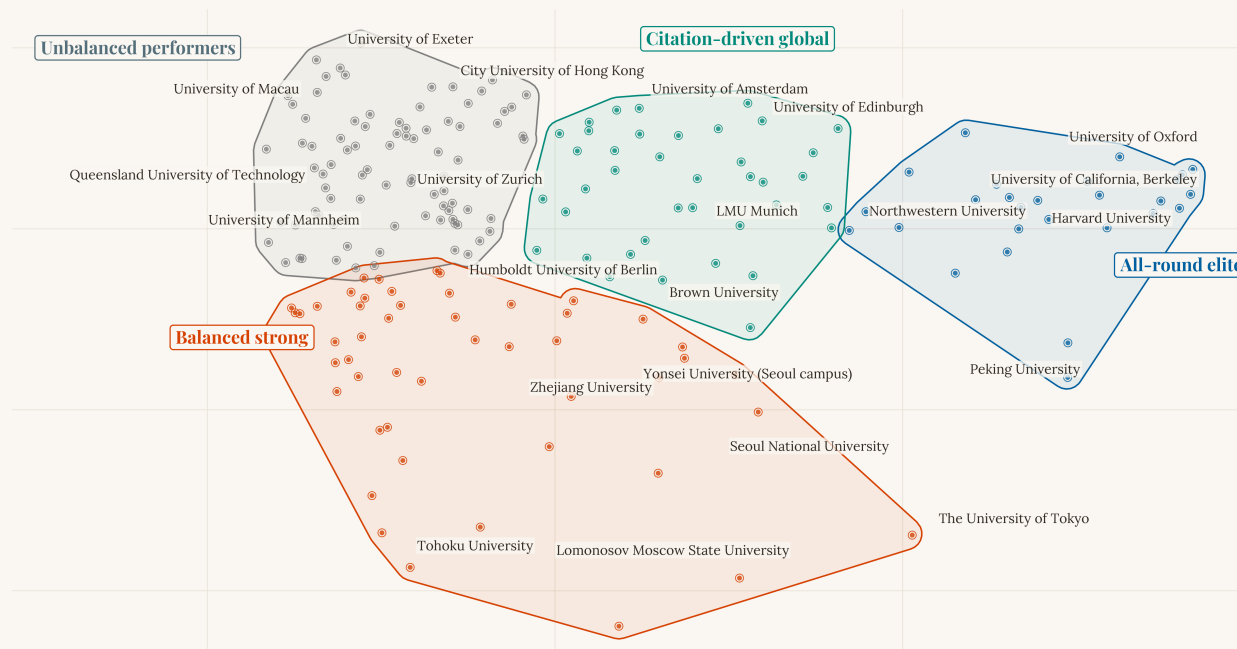


Source: Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2024.
Groups defined by k-means clustering on teaching, research, citations, and international outlook scores.

According with the documentation of the scores calculation provided by [THE](#), **research score** reflects a university's research capacity through its peer-perceived reputation, the research income it secures, and its productivity in publishing peer-reviewed papers, making it largely a perception-based measure. **Citation score**, in contrast, measures the actual impact of that research through bibliometric evidence: how often its papers are cited globally, how strong its typical research is (field-weighted citation impact), how much of its output ranks in the world's top 10%, and whether citations come from influential papers rather than unimportant ones.

Same top 200, four different neighborhoods.

Even within the global top 200, excellence clusters into distinct profiles.

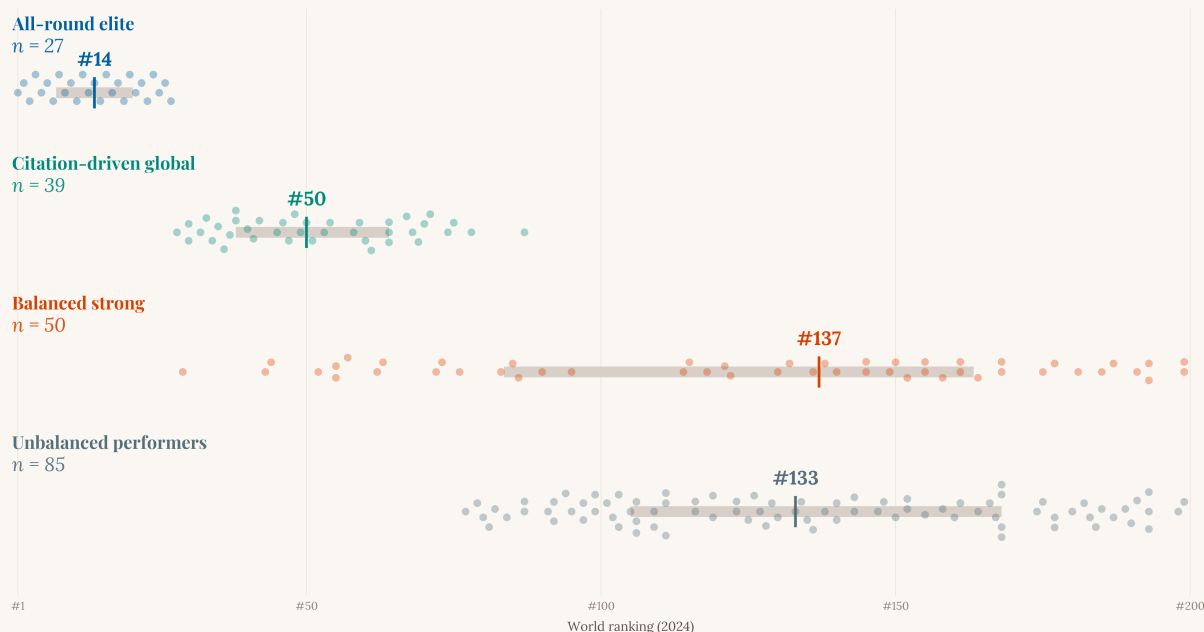


Source: Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2024.
Groups are mutually exclusive — each university belongs to exactly one. The two-dimensional map is a simplification for display purposes; apparent overlaps are visual, not real.

These groups do not just differ in rank. They differ in profile. All-round elite universities remain strong across all four dimensions, while the other groups rely on narrower advantages. Excellence has distinct shapes, not just different levels.

Not all models of excellence reach the top equally.

Distribution of 2024 world rankings within each group. Each dot is a university. The bar shows the interquartile range; the line marks the median.

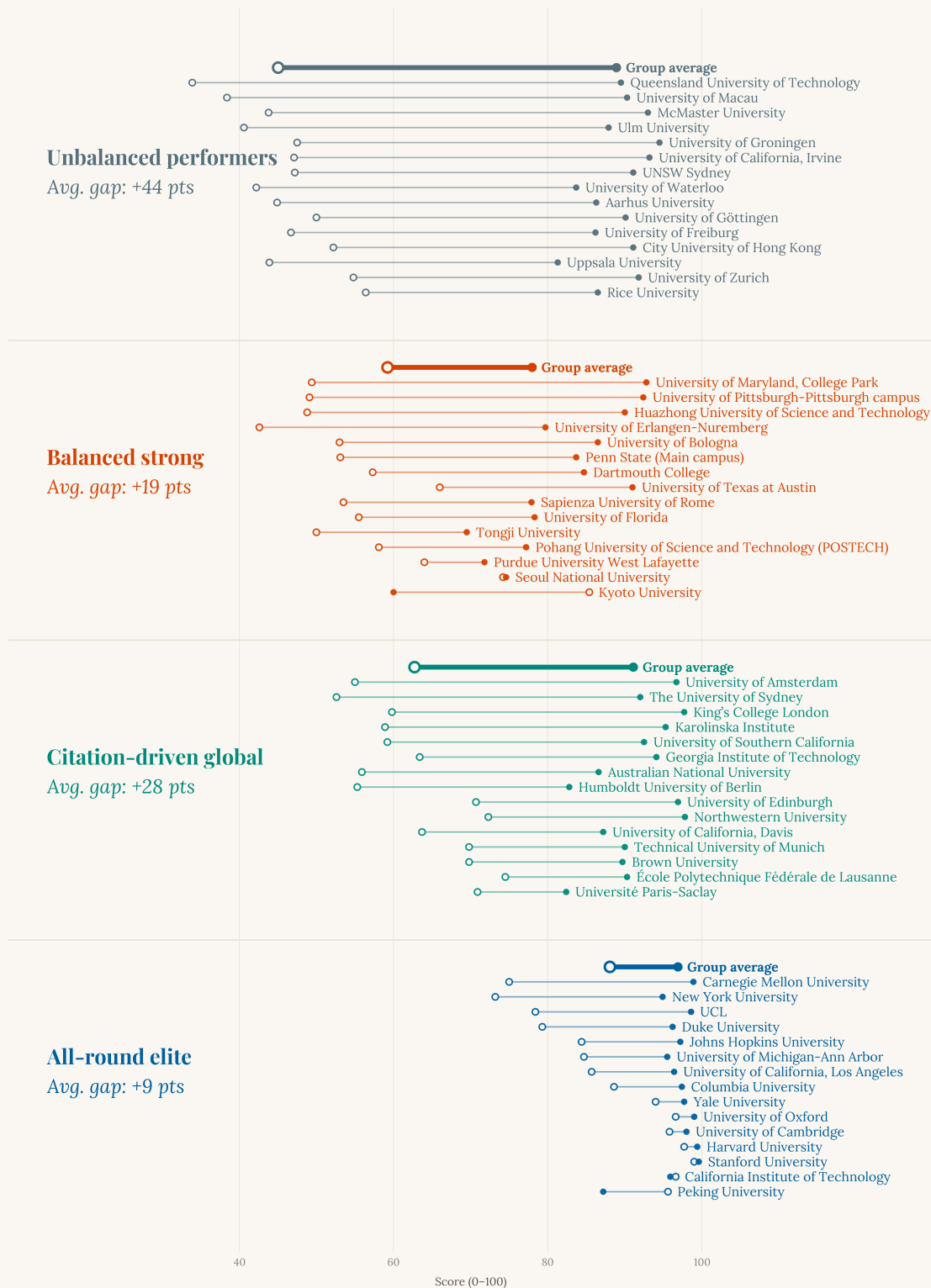


Source: Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2024.

Those profiles do not reach the top equally. All-round elite universities dominate the very top, and citation driven global institutions are close behind. Balanced strong and unbalanced performers are spread much more widely.

Citations and teaching rarely peak together

Each line connects a university's teaching score (open dot) to its citations score (filled dot). Longer lines signal a stronger trade-off. Universities ordered by gap within each group.



Source: Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2024.
Random sample of 15 universities per group. Average gap calculated on all 201 universities.

Teaching and citations often pull in different directions. Unbalanced performers and citation driven global universities tend to earn much stronger citation scores than teaching scores. Only the All-round elite keeps both dimensions high at once. Very few universities manage both.

The elite remains. Everyone else shifted.

Ranking trajectories of 148 universities present in both 2019 and 2024. Colored by 2024 group. Highlighted lines moved 20+ positions. No All-round elite university moved.



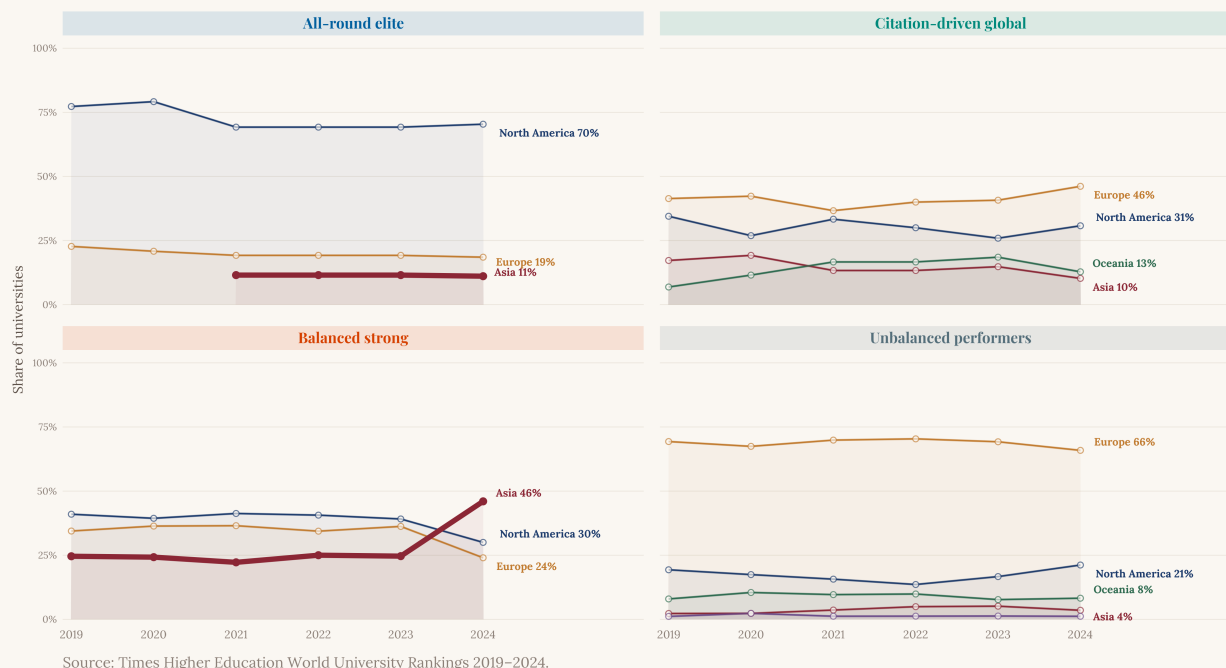
Across five years, the elite didn't move. The largest gains came from universities outside that group, especially in Asia, while several American and European institutions lost ground. The very top stayed stable, but the rest of the field did not.

Additional note on Asia

Is Asia changing the map of global higher education?

Share of universities per continent within each group, 2019–2024.

In *Balanced strong*, Asia grew from 23% to 46% overtaking North America and Europe in just five years.



Source: Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2019–2024.

One geographic shift stands out. In the *balanced strong* group, Asia nearly doubled its share in five years and moved ahead of North America and Europe. No other group changed that sharply. The map of excellence is beginning to shift.

Only All-round elite universities reach truly high research environment scores, a dimension that, according to THE's documentation, largely measures perceived reputation rather than current output. It is the strongest differentiator of the elite, and also the hardest to change.

Yet the universities that climbed the most over the past five years did not win reputation overnight; they did it through citation impact, research that travels, gets cited, and stands out in its field. The path to the top is not about looking elite, but about producing research the world cannot ignore.